No.3 Nick

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Nick analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Nick by Christina Rossetti contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Nick

Christina Rossetti's short story Nick was written in 1853, and is part of a collection called Commonplace and Other Stories. The cautionary tale follows the dissatisfied **protagonist**, Nick, who lives in a fairytale village.

Nick has a comfortable life. He is self-sufficient, and has a thriving farm. But he is envious of all the things his neighbours have. Despite his own material wealth, Nick is jealous and wishes bad luck and harm on his neighbours.

To teach him a lesson, a magical "little rosy woman" the size of a "butterfly" appears to Nick. She tells him he has the power to wish to be anything he likes for an hour at a time. So follows a series of Nick's poorly-intended wishes. First of all, he wishes to become a flock of sparrows to attack his neighbour's cherries. When he is shot down and attacked by a cat, he wishes to be a dog. In the form of a dog he attacks the cat, which leads the townspeople to chase him. To save himself, Nick turns himself into a stick, but is taken home by one of the villagers, where he is thrown into their fire.

A furious Nick then decides to transform himself in the fire itself, so he can burn the villager's house down in revenge. As he does so, he is doused with water and becomes a small flame. At this point, an exhausted Nick finally realises his

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Eager to make a good wish, he wishes to be a rich old man so he can help the villagers, but, that very night, robbers break in and steal his possessions and plan to murder him. As he lies in his own grave, he wishes to be himself once more, and manages to escape.

Back home, a humbler man, Nick seeks redemption by fixing all the damage he has done, and never wishes for anything else again.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. This will help you to form a structural analysis, which means you will be considering how themes and characters develop (or not) through the story.

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Nick

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Christina Rossetti's Nick.

What are the key themes in Nick?

Theme	Analysis

Envy	• Rossetti's **protagonist** Nick is described as "poor" despite an abundant life:
	  ○ This conveys the idea of envy as a state of poverty
	  ○ It encourages the reader to challenge traditional ideas of wealth and consider the real meaning of contentment
	• Nick's desires for more than he already has, and his jealousy of what others have, manifest in self-pity:
	  ○ Rossetti makes it clear that Nick's home is the "prettiest and snuggest in all the place"
	  ○ Yet he "would sit grumbling and bemoaning himself as if every other man's riches were his poverty"
	• Rossetti delivers messages about wanting more through the symbolic idea of "wishes":

Help me understand

Redemption	• Rossetti's story progresses through a series of ironic consequences to Nick's poor choices:
	  ○ For instance, he changes into a stick to escape the angry villagers, only to be thrown onto a fire
	
	• Nick's transformations are symbolic in that they constitute painful lessons:
	  ○ As a bird he is attacked by a cat: he "chirped in desperation"
	  ○ As a fire, he is "surrounded by a wall of wet ashes" where he "sat and smouldered"
	
	• Rossetti alludes to self-sacrifice as a means to salvation:
	  ○ After he wishes to be a stick, Nick is thrown on the villager's fire and "crackled and blazed away cheerfully"
	  ○ Nick must become humble, grateful, and pay back his victims in order to find a sense of peace
	
	• The story suggests redemption is a "deliverance":
	  ○ Nick's "reflection" and silent "pondering" help him see his mistakes
	  ○ Nick's change is signalled dramatically: "His wish suddenly found vent in a prolonged unearthly yell"
	  ○ Rossetti refers to Nick as "our hero"

Writer's Methods in Nick

How does Rossetti present her ideas and perspectives?

Rossetti uses natural imagery and a traditional narrative structure to create an allegory.

Technique	Analysis

Symbolism	• Rossetti's story is an **allegory** that delivers messages about **karma** or retribution:
	  ○ Nick's choices are symbolised by wishes
	  ○ The fire that Nick turns into is presented as a purifying element once he becomes "one blue flame" and reflects on his actions

	"wholesome herbs"
	• The fairy represents a supernatural being who appears to teach a human being a lesson:
	  ○ This character is typical in fairytales, like Beauty and the Beast, and **didactic** prose like Charles Dickens' A Christmas Carol
	  ○ Often, such supernatural guardians of morality are described as small, yet fierce
	  ○ Rossetti's "rosy" fairy is as small as a "butterfly", but has a "menacing attitude" and looks at Nick "scornfully"

Omniscient narrator	• The story begins in typical fairy-tale style:
	  ○ "There dwelt in a small village, not a thousand miles from Fairyland"
	• Rossetti's third-person omniscient narrator is conversational:
	  ○ "When I call him poor, you must not suppose he was a homeless wanderer"
	• The story progresses through a linear narrative to show Nick's development as a character as a result of events
	• Typical for a fairytale, Rossetti characterises her **protagonist** as a hero despite his flaws:
	  ○ "Up jumped our hero"
	  ○ Rossetti **ironically** calls Nick "our hero", who only becomes sympathetic after his redemption
	• Interestingly, Rossetti's final line alludes to fairytale villains that are often never heard of more:
	  ○ Despite his redemption, the story ends "Nick was never again heard to utter a wish"

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners report that the best answers to the prose question focus on the authors' choices of language and literary methods, and the effects these might have on a reader. You will be rewarded for a thoughtful argument that is closely supported by detailed references to the text, and analysis of the writer's choices.

For example, in the short story Nick, Christina Rossetti explores ideas about envy by using the literary form of a

Key quotations in Nick

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. Remember, though, that summarising, paraphrasing, referencing single words, and referencing plot events are all considered valid supporting evidence for your points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Christina Rossetti's Nick, arranged by the following themes:

- **Envy**
- **Redemption**

Envy

In Christina Rossetti's story Nick, the **protagonist** is a fortunate and successful man, but he looks upon his neighbours' possessions with jealousy, and thinks that if they had less he would have more.

> **"It was in vain that his apples were the largest for miles around" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The narrator says that even though Nick's apples were the best in the whole village and beyond, it was for nothing as Nick did not appreciate them

Analysis

- This line is the first of two that lists Nick's successes
- The **narrator** suggests the idea of waste in the phrase "It was in vain", implying he might as well not have had anything at all
- Rossetti shows that abundance cannot bring happiness if jealousy exists:
    - Despite Nick having the best apples, and "lambs" that were "fat and thriving", he cannot enjoy them

> **"He would sit grumbling and bemoaning himself as if every other man's riches were his poverty" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The narrator describes how Nick becomes unhappy and resentful because he is jealous of others' possessions

bemoaning" to present Nick as constantly miserable as a result of his envy
- Rossetti suggests envy leads to a kind of poverty:
  - She implies that his perception of being less well off than his neighbours means he sees himself as poorer than them

- Rossetti presents envy as socially destructive, as well as personally damaging:
  - His resentment at others' success leads to his isolation
  - He has no "family to labour for or friend to assist"

> **"It was provocation enough to be burned; but to contribute by his misfortune to the well-being of his tormentors was still more aggravating" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Even as Nick (in the form of a stick in the villager's fire) burns, he is envious that his "tormentors" are enjoying the warmth he creates
- This is even more annoying than being burned

Analysis

- Rossetti shows how envy can lead one to be spiteful even at one's own expense
- That Nick is more annoyed by the "well-being" of the villagers than the fact he is being burned is humorous
- Rossetti suggests envy is irrational and foolish

Redemption

> **"Then she gave him a slap in the face, which made his cheek tingle as if a bee had stung him" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- The "little rosy woman" (a fairy) tells Nick that he "shall straightway become everything" he wishes, and then slaps him for being a "churl" (a rude person)
- The "slap" makes his "cheek" sting

Analysis

- Rossetti uses a **simile** to compare the "slap" to a bee sting
- This connotes to a punishment, or a shock that aims to awaken Nick
- Rossetti implies that redemption is a painful process
- Natural **imagery** (a "bee") contributes to the story's simplistic, fairy-tale style

Meaning and context

- As Nick smoulders as "one blue flame", he reflects on his actions
- He decides that his next wish should be one that benefits him but does not harm his neighbours
- As he wishes to become a "rich old man", he burns out

Analysis

- Rossetti perhaps uses Nick's transformation into fire as symbolic:
  - Fire is often used as a symbol either of ultimate punishment or purification
- Indeed, Nick finally learns an important lesson when he is reduced to a "blue flame":
  - His own success should not be at the expense of others

> **"And now entertained only one wish — that he were himself again" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Finally, Nick makes his last wish, to transform back into "himself"

Analysis

- Rossetti's presentation of the theme of redemption is delivered via the painful and humiliating consequences of Nick's badly intended wishes
- By the end of the story, Rossetti implies that Nick's sins, his ungratefulness and his spiteful jealousy, are redeemed through humility
- That Nick wishes to be "himself again" culminates his cyclical journey of self-development

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.

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